

# FORESTS

About 30 percent of Earth's land surface is covered by forest, which provides some of the richest of all habitats. At high latitudes, between 53° and 67°N, are the huge boreal forests of North America and Eurasia, which are dominated by coniferous trees. Between 10°S and 10°N are the world's

great tropical rain forests, including the Amazon and Congo, regions of great biodiversity. In between are a wide variety of subtropical and temperate forests, some of the latter being rain forests. Russia has the greatest area of forest and Suriname, the greatest proportion of cover.

## North America

### The Tongass National Forest

**Location** Alaska, northwest U.S.

Covering most of southeast Alaska, this is the largest national forest in the U.S., at 26,640 square miles (69,000 square km). It is part of the Pacific Northwest Rain Forest, Earth's largest temperate rain forest. The dominant trees are red cedar, sitka spruce, and western hemlock. Logging of old-growth forest is strictly controlled. Brown and black bears live in the forest. The region also supports large populations of breeding birds.

### The Redwood National Forest

**Location** California, western U.S.

Half of the world's remaining old-growth coast redwood trees — the tallest on Earth—are protected within this forest reserve. One, Hyperion, is 380 ft (116 m) tall. Coast redwoods are native to coastal northern California and southern Oregon. Black bears, cougars, beavers, flying squirrels, and more than 400 species of birds have been recorded in the forest, which covers 61 square miles (158 square km).

► SNOW-COVERED TREES AT THE TONGASS NATIONAL FOREST

### Californian Chaparral and Woodland

**Location** California and Baja California, western U.S. and northern Mexico

Many coastal areas of central and southern California, the Central Valley, and Baja California are characterized by this scrub-dominated environment. Scrub oaks, sages, and *Ceanothus* are typical plants, and the flora is well adapted to recover from frequent wildfires. The climate

is a Mediterranean type, with warm, wet winters and hot, dry summers.

### The Sierra Madre Pine-Oak Forest

**Location** Between Jalisco state, northwest Mexico, and New Mexico, southwest U.S.

Large areas of these subtropical mixed forests survive at high altitudes in the dramatic

mountains and steep-sided valleys of the Sierra Madre Occidental, although much has also been logged. Typical trees in the region include several species of pine, Douglas fir, Emory oak, and Mexican blue oak. The forests are home to black bears, jaguars, and more than 300 breeding birds, including some that are found nowhere else on Earth—the thick-billed parrot, eared quetzal, military macaw, Sinaloa martin, golden eagle, and tufted jay.

